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The First Indo-Pakistani War

The earliest written history of South Asia, Kashmir's ancient *Rājataranginī* (River of Kings), dating back to 1148 C.E., records both the wisdom of Kashmir's greatest rulers and the cruelty of its most violent.[1] Its first author, Kalhana, commences by bowing to the Hindu Lord Shiva, whose many consorts include the mother goddess Parvati, one of whose terrestrial names was Kashmira. India's great Buddhist emperor Aśoka, who reigned over Mauryan India from 269 to 232 B.C.E., founded Kashmir's capital of Srinagar on the banks of the river Vitasta during his brief visit to that peaceful valley. The lovely city, which soon embraced Dal Lake and later came to be called the Venice of India, lured to its garden-filled precincts people of every faith: Hindu, Muslim, Buddhist, and Christian. Their craftsmanship and artistry blended to create a uniquely tolerant, beautifully harmonious eclectic culture called Kashmiryat, a microcosmic reflection of South Asia's complexity.

Kanishka, the greatest Central Asian Kushana monarch who conquered North India, whose reign spanned two decades around 100 C.E., hosted a Buddhist council at a monastery near Srinagar. He invited to Kashmir Chinese as well as Indian monks, who are said to have recorded all 300,000 stanzas of Mahayana Buddhism's *Tripitaka* canon on copper plates, which unfortunately have since been lost. Kashmir's northwestern region, Ladakh, with its capital of Leh, has since Kanishka's reign remained Buddhist.

During the eighth century, Kashmir expanded into Tibet under the "Alexander" of Kashmiri history, the Hindu warrior-king Lalitaditya, whose appetite for conquest added as much to his kingdom's prosperity as to its territory. Lalitaditya, Kashmir's most powerful Hindu monarch,